

Infinity Aero Club Tampa Bay | Mission Aviation Academy

Aviation & Aerospace Complete Career Pathway Guide

CAREER GUIDE

Where to Start · What to Explore · How to Get There

19 Sections | 7 Career Families | Tampa North Aero Park (X39), Wesley Chapel, FL | Version 7 · Fall 2026

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Aviation is bigger than the cockpit. Explore every career the sky has to offer.

About This Guide & Our Partnerships

Our Legal Structure

Mission Aviation Academy (MAA) is the academic division of Infinity Aero Club Tampa Bay, Inc. (iACT), a Florida 501(c)(3) nonprofit flying club. MAA operates as a DBA (doing business as) of iACT for official filing and tax purposes.

Not a Flight School: iACT/MAA is not a certificated flight school and does not hold an FAA Part 61 or Part 141 school certificate.

Flight Training Partners

Flight instruction is delivered by Central Florida Flight Training (Erik Meredith, Owner/Chief CFI — CFI/CFII/MEI/AGI/IGI, Gold Seal — Zephyrhills, FL) and Wings of an Angel Aviation (Josh Torres, CFI — Tampa, FL).

Maintenance training: Hangar 777, LLC (Jurupa Valley, CA), FAA-accepted LSRM provider.

Our CFIs & Aircraft

MAA-affiliated CFIs Matthews, Mednick, and Floyd conduct certificate flight instruction through our partner schools' aircraft.

MAA's own Cessna 172 is for discovery flights and flying club rental only.

Scholarship: MAA is an approved Florida SUFS provider. PHSC and JROTC/ROTC partner.

★ *PLEASE NOTE: Program partners, schedules, and availability are subject to change. Contact MAA directly to confirm current details before enrolling or relying on any specific date in this guide.*

What's Inside — Nineteen Sections

Seven career families, four action steps, engineering deep dives, eVTOL, helicopter, the sport pilot and glider ladder, and the Wealth Ladder from Your Aviation Blueprint.

SECTION	WHAT IT COVERS	PRIORITY
1 — The 7 Career Families	Every lane in aviation and aerospace, and which require flying	START HERE
2 — Flight Operations	FAA certificate ladder, Student Pilot through ATP, where to train	HIGH
3 — Corporate Pilot & Independent CFI	Business aviation, freelance instructing, and four-track comparison	NEW v6
4 — Aviation Maintenance	A&P, IA, and avionics credentials; national mechanic shortage	NO DEGREE
5 — UAS / Drone Operations	Part 107, waivers, and seven industries hiring now	FASTEST ENTRY
6 — Air Traffic & Safety	ATC, FAA safety inspection, flight service, airport operations	AGE-CAPPED
7 — Aerospace & Defense	Engineering, intelligence, cyber, program management, manufacturing	HIGH
8 — Management & Education	Dispatch, airport leadership, logistics, curriculum, insurance	MEDIUM
9 — Where to Go Next	Explore, Connect, Train, Apply — named resources and funding	ACTION
10 — Salary Snapshot	Industry ranges plus BLS-verified national medians	REFERENCE
11–14 — Plan Your Path	Cost, timeline, eligibility, the 80% problem, first 12 months	PLANNING
15 — Sport Pilot & Glider	Age gates, MOSAIC, stacked route, what each rung pays	v6
16 — The Wealth Ladder	Age 14 to 30, from Your Aviation Blueprint v11.22	v6
17 — Aerospace, Space & Engineering	Deep dive: specializations, pay by employer, space economy track	NEW v7
18 — eVTOL & Urban Air Mobility	Powered-lift rating, who is hiring, salary, what to do now	NEW v7
19 — Helicopter Pilot	Seven civilian sectors, training path, hour requirements, pay	NEW v7

The Numbers Behind the Opportunity

PILOTS NEEDED

674,000

New pilots required worldwide over the next 20 years (Boeing Pilot & Technician Outlook 2026–2045).

TECHNICIANS NEEDED

728,000

New maintenance technicians required worldwide over the same period.

CABIN CREW NEEDED

1,023,000

Over 2.4 million aviation professionals in total.

REMOTE PILOTS

493,396

FAA remote pilot certificates issued through Dec 2025; projected 628,600 by 2030.

PRESSURE POINT	WHAT THE DATA SHOWS	SOURCE
Mechanic shortage	10% shortage of certificated mechanics in 2025; still 7% — about 10,000 — in 2035	ATEC / Oliver Wyman 2025 Pipeline Report
Empty training seats	Roughly one-third of A&P school seats sit unfilled — awareness, not capacity, is the constraint	ATEC 2025 Pipeline Report
Controller pipeline	FAA actively hiring; average certified earnings exceed $155,000 within 3 years of Academy graduation	FAA ATC hiring (faa.gov/atc-hiring)
Retirement-driven demand	About two-thirds of the 20-year personnel demand comes from attrition and retirements	Boeing PTO

★ **THE BOTTOM LINE:** The shortage is not a talking point. It is a documented, decade-long gap between the number of people the industry needs and the number entering the pipeline.

“Underserved” Is an Economic Condition, Not a Color

Aviation has always had a recruitment problem. But the language used to describe it has been imprecise — and imprecision costs money, credibility, and students.

UNDERSERVED — THE DEFINITION THAT MATTERS

A community or population that has been systematically denied full opportunity to participate in economic, social, and civic life — specifically because of limited access to:

- Affordable, quality education and credentialing pathways
- Economic stability — income, housing, food security
- Healthcare and transportation infrastructure
- Broadband, technology, and labor market information
- Geographic proximity to opportunity (rural isolation counts)

Rural family of any background
No flight school within 200 miles. No high school STEM elective. No internet fast enough to stream ground school.

Urban family of any background
Underfunded school. No aviation exposure. One medical bill from bankruptcy. The sky looks like it belongs to someone else.

Immigrant family
Language barrier. No professional network. No one in the household has ever been near a cockpit.

Single parent, any race
Two jobs. No margin for a $15,000 path. No one told them Part 107 costs $175 and 6 weeks.

★ **MAA'S MISSION:** MAA serves anyone who was told the sky wasn't for them — for any reason. That is an economic and access statement, not a demographic one.

SECTION 1

The 7 Career Families of Aviation & Aerospace

Aviation and aerospace careers fall into seven broad families. You do not have to be a pilot to have a career in the sky.

Only 2 of the 7 families require flying at all.

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The 7 Career Families

CAREER FAMILY	EXAMPLE ROLES	REQUIRES FLYING?
Flight Operations	Pilot, CFI, Check Airman, Air Carrier Ops	Yes
Aviation Maintenance	A&P Mechanic, Avionics Tech, Inspector, IA	No
Air Traffic & Safety	ATC Controller, Safety Inspector, FSS Specialist	No
UAS / Drone Operations	Drone Pilot, UAS Operator, Mapping Tech	Part 107 only
Aerospace & Defense	Aerospace Engineer, Systems Analyst, Test Tech	No
Aviation Management	Airport Director, Dispatcher, Logistics Manager	No
Education & Training	CFI, Sim Instructor, Curriculum Developer	Sometimes

★ **CAREER ALERT:** Pick the family first — the credential comes second. Five of the seven families never require you to touch the controls.

SECTION 2

Flight Operations: The Pilot Pathway

The FAA certificate ladder is sequential and public. Every rung has published hour minimums, a written exam, and a checkride.

ATP minimums drop to 1,000 hrs with a degree — 750 hrs with military time.

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FAA Certificate Roadmap

CERTIFICATE / RATING	MINIMUM REQUIREMENTS & NOTES
Student Pilot Certificate	Age 16 (14 for glider/balloon); FAA medical; no written exam required
Private Pilot License (PPL)	40 hrs total (20 dual, 10 solo minimum); written exam + checkride
Instrument Rating (IR)	50 hrs cross-country PIC; 40 hrs instrument time; written + checkride
Commercial Pilot (CPL)	250 hrs total time; written + checkride; you can now be paid to fly
Certified Flight Instructor (CFI)	CPL + instrument rating; written + checkride; teach and build hours
Airline Transport Pilot (ATP)	1,500 hrs (1,000 w/ college degree; 750 w/ military); First Class medical

★ **CAREER ALERT:** Each rung is a job, not just a step. CFI is the rung that pays you to accumulate the hours the ATP requires.

Where to Train — Five Routes to the Left Seat

Part 61 Flight Schools
Flexible scheduling, pay-as-you-go. Most local FBOs — including the field at X39.

Part 141 Flight Schools
Structured curriculum on an FAA-approved syllabus; fewer total hours required.

University Aviation Programs
B.S. degree plus flight certificates combined — Embry-Riddle, FAMU, Purdue, and others.

Military Service
The most direct funded path. Air Force, Navy, Army, Coast Guard, and Marine Corps all train pilots.

Community College Bridge Programs
Affordable entry point before a university transfer; often Pell-eligible.

★ **CAREER ALERT:** Five routes, one certificate. Cost and schedule differ; the FAA practical test standard does not.

SECTION 3

Corporate Pilot & Independent CFI

Two pilot-career tracks most guides skip — flying for a company instead of an airline, and building a freelance instructing business.

Corporate captains now average $188,800+ — closing the gap with major-airline pay.

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Corporate & Charter Pilot: Flying for a Company, Not an Airline

ROLE	DETAILS
Corporate / Charter First Officer (Entry)	Smaller business aircraft (light jets, turboprops); Commercial + Instrument rating, 500–1,500 total hours
Corporate Captain — Mid-Size Cabin	Type-rated PIC on Citation or Learjet family; ATP typically required; $130K–$180K/yr
Corporate Captain — Large-Cabin / Long-Range	Gulfstream, Global, and Falcon-class jets; the highest-paying corporate cockpit seat; $220K–$350K+
Chief Pilot / Aviation Dept. Manager	Oversees flight dept. operations, scheduling, and safety compliance — a non-flying leadership track
Path In	ATP certificate plus type rating(s); most operators hire pilots with Part 135 charter or airline-adjacent flight time

★ **CAREER ALERT:** 2026 average pay across all business-aviation positions: $202,499 (BizJetJobs survey, 2,847 pilots). Large-cabin captains: $220K–$350K+.

The Independent CFI: Building a Freelance Instructing Business

STRUCTURE	DETAILS
W-2 Flight School CFI (Employed)	Typical 2026 pay: $35K–$60K base plus $8K–$15K benefits ($43K–$75K total); scheduled students, supplied aircraft
1099 Independent CFI	Bills students directly; supplies own insurance, aircraft access, and marketing — a P&L decision, not a lifestyle choice
Independent Hourly Rates	$45–$65/hr new instructors in average markets; established independents $50–$125/hr; up to $150–$300/hr for type-specific training
Realistic Income	50–70 flight hrs/month once established; $35K–$95K+ annually depending on hours and rate
Insurance & Liability	Avemco non-owned CFI liability policies run $160–$510/yr; professional liability needs a separate policy

★ **CAREER ALERT:** Self-employment tax takes an effective ~14% off the top of 1099 income — the single biggest math mistake new independents make.

Corporate vs. Airline vs. Military vs. CFI / Flight School Owner

TRACK	ENTRY PAY · TOP PAY · PATH IN
Corporate / Charter Pilot	Entry $90K–$120K · Top (large-cabin captain) $220K–$350K+ · Path: ATP + type rating, Part 91 / Part 135 charter time
Major Airline Pilot	Entry $80K–$100K (regional) · Top (senior captain) $250K–$350K+ · Path: ATP (1,500 hrs), seniority-driven ladder
Military Pilot	Entry: flight pay + BAH + benefits · Top: senior officer command pay + pension · Path: commissioning source, service flight school, zero personal training cost
CFI / Flight School Owner	Entry $35K–$60K (W-2) or $45–$65/hr (1099) · Top $95K+ owning a school · Path: CFI certificate, build student base or start/buy a school
Which Fits You	Corporate = steady schedule, strong ceiling · Airline = highest ceiling, seniority grind · Military = zero personal training cost · CFI = fastest income, caps sooner

★ **CAREER ALERT:** This is the comparison table most career guides skip. Share it with every student choosing between flight school employment and starting their own practice.

Business Aviation Careers: Beyond the Cockpit

ROLE	SALARY & PATH IN
Aircraft Sales Broker	Commission: 2–5% per deal; aircraft range $300K–$75M+. Top brokers earn $200K–$1M+/yr. No FAA license required.
FBO / Ground Operations Manager	Oversees fuel, hangar, ramp, and customer ops. Salary: $65K–$110K. Path: aviation management degree or ops experience.
Charter Sales & Operations Coordinator	Sells and schedules Part 135 charter flights. Ops: $45K–$75K. Senior charter sales: $80K–$120K+.
Business Aviation Director / VP of Aviation	Leads a corporate flight department. Salary: $120K–$250K+. Path: ATP + management experience or MBA.

★ **CAREER ALERT:** Business aviation careers outside the cockpit are among the least-advertised and best-compensated roles in the guide. Aircraft brokerage in particular has no degree requirement and a wide-open income ceiling.

SECTION 4

Aviation Maintenance: A&P & Avionics

Maintenance professionals keep aircraft airworthy. No flying required, no four-year degree required, and the shortage is documented.

728,000 new maintenance technicians needed worldwide over 20 years.

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Maintenance Credentials & How to Earn Them

CREDENTIAL	PATH TO GET THERE
A&P Certificate (Airframe & Powerplant)	FAA Part 147 school (18–24 months) OR 30 months documented hands-on experience, then written / oral / practical tests
Inspection Authorization (IA)	3 years as an A&P + annual exercise + FAA approval; allows independent aircraft inspections
Avionics Technician	A&P or FCC license; focus on avionics and aircraft electronics systems
FAA Light Sport Repairman (LSRM)	100 hours on a specific aircraft type; covers light sport maintenance
Military MOS → Civilian Credit	Military aircraft mechanic experience counts toward A&P eligibility

★ **CAREER ALERT:** BLS puts the aircraft mechanic median at $78,680 and avionics technicians at $81,390 (May 2024) — with no four-year degree required.

Where to Train — Maintenance

FAA Part 147 Aviation Maintenance Technician Schools
The full directory of approved schools is published at faa.gov.

Named Programs
Embry-Riddle Aeronautical University, Northland Pioneer College, Lake Area Tech, and others.

Community & Technical Colleges
A&P programs at local colleges — the lowest-cost civilian route.

Military Service
Air Force 2A series, Navy AD / AE / AME ratings, Army 15-series MOS.

★ **VETERAN NOTE:** Document every maintenance hour you logged in uniform — it converts directly into A&P test eligibility.

SECTION 5

UAS / Drone Operations: The Fastest Entry Point

Part 107 certification is the lowest barrier to a legitimate aviation career — no flight test, no medical, minimum age 16.

493,396 FAA remote pilot certificates issued through December 2025.

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Part 107 Credentials & Roles

CREDENTIAL / ROLE	DETAILS
FAA Part 107 Remote Pilot Certificate	Minimum age 16; pass the Aeronautical Knowledge Test; no flight test required; valid 24 months
Advanced Operations Waiver	Apply to the FAA for BVLOS, night operations, and operations over people
Industry Certifications	DJI certified, Autel, senseFly — manufacturer-specific training
UAS Operator / Mission Specialist	Real estate, agriculture, public safety, film, infrastructure inspection
Drone Data Analyst	GIS, photogrammetry, mapping, and thermal imaging analysis

★ **CAREER ALERT:** Certificate in weeks, not years. MAA teaches this course directly at X39 — then you stack an industry specialty on top of it.

Industries Hiring Drone Operators Now

Public Safety Law enforcement, fire service, search and rescue.
Typical roles: UAS unit operator, tactical flight officer

Construction & Infrastructure Site surveys, bridge and pipeline inspection.
Typical roles: Survey pilot, documentation technician

Logistics & Delivery Amazon, UPS Flight Forward, Wing.
Typical roles: Delivery UAS operator, fleet technician

Environmental Monitoring Wildlife surveys, climate research, conservation.
Typical roles: Survey pilot, thermal imaging analyst

Agriculture Precision farming, crop health monitoring, yield mapping.
Typical roles: Spray operator, crop-scouting pilot

Real Estate & Media Photography, videography, listing and campaign marketing.
Typical roles: Listing pilot, aerial cinematographer

Military & Defense ISR and reconnaissance work under DoD contracts.
Typical roles: Sensor operator, contractor UAS technician

★ **CAREER ALERT:** Construction, energy, and agriculture are the largest commercial drone verticals. The specialty you choose sets the pay ceiling.

SECTION 6

Air Traffic Control & Aviation Safety

Federal aviation careers with published pay scales, structured hiring pipelines, and no flying requirement.

FAA hiring requires you to be under 31 at application — plan early.

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Air Traffic & Safety Careers

CAREER	PATH & NOTES
Air Traffic Controller (FAA)	AT-CTI college program OR military ATC experience; must be under 31 at application; FAA reports average certified earnings above $155,000 within 3 years of Academy graduation
FAA Aviation Safety Inspector	A&P or pilot certificate plus experience; federal GS-12 to GS-15 pay scale
Flight Service Specialist	Weather briefings, NOTAMs, ATC support; contractors such as Leidos hire regularly
Safety Management Systems (SMS)	Airlines and airports hire SMS specialists; degree plus aviation experience preferred
Airport Operations	ARFF, ramp control, operations coordinator; city / county government jobs and TSA

★ **TIME-CRITICAL:** The FAA requires applicants to be under 31 at application. Certain preference-eligible veterans with qualifying ATC experience may be considered beyond that age — verify against the specific USAJOBS announcement.

Where to Start for ATC

FAA AT-CTI Schools
Approved college programs that feed directly into FAA hiring announcements.

Military ATC
Air Force 1C1X1, Army 15Q, Navy AC — the most direct path into the FAA pipeline.

FAA Academy — Oklahoma City
Required training for selected candidates, followed by 1–3 years of on-the-job training.

usajobs.gov
Search series 2152 (Air Traffic Control) and 1825 (Aviation Safety). Candidates must pass the ATSA.

★ **ACTION ITEM:** Set a usajobs.gov alert today. FAA ATC bids open and close in days.

SECTION 7

Aerospace Engineering & Defense

The aerospace and defense sector employs 2.5 million Americans and exports more than any other U.S. manufacturing sector.

You do not need to be an engineer to work here.

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Roles, Degrees & Employers

ROLE	DEGREE / CREDENTIAL NEEDED	EMPLOYERS
Aerospace Engineer	B.S. Aerospace or Mechanical Engineering	NASA, Boeing, Lockheed, SpaceX
Systems Analyst	B.S. Systems or Engineering	Northrop Grumman, Raytheon, SAIC
Cybersecurity / Space	B.S. Computer Science + Security+ or CEH	Space Force, NSA, L3Harris
Intelligence Analyst	B.S. any field + TS/SCI clearance	DIA, NGA, SOCOM, defense contractors
Program Manager	PMP + aviation or defense experience	All major primes and DoD agencies
Manufacturing Technician	2-year degree or vocational certificate	Boeing, Spirit AeroSystems, GE Aviation

★ **CAREER ALERT:** A security clearance is a credential. BLS puts aerospace engineers at a $134,830 median and aerospace engineering technicians at $79,830 (May 2024). See Section 17 for the deep-dive on this field.

Top Employers — Aerospace & Defense

LEGACY DEFENSE PRIMES

Boeing · Lockheed Martin · Northrop Grumman · Raytheon · General Dynamics

SPACE & NEW ENTRANTS

NASA · SpaceX · Blue Origin · Sierra Nevada Corporation · Rocket Lab

TECHNOLOGY & SERVICES

L3Harris · SAIC · Leidos · Booz Allen Hamilton · CACI

FEDERAL & MILITARY

U.S. Space Force · U.S. Air Force · SOCOM · DIA · NGA

★ **CAREER ALERT:** Every organization on this slide hires technicians, analysts, and program managers — not only engineers. See Section 17 for specialization pay and space economy roles.

SECTION 8

Aviation Education, Management & Logistics

The business side of aviation: dispatch, airport leadership, supply chain, training, and insurance.

Aircraft Dispatcher — a licensed airline career built on roughly 200 hours of study.

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Management, Education & Logistics Careers

CAREER	HOW TO GET THERE
Aircraft Dispatcher	FAA Aircraft Dispatcher License; approximately 200 hours of study; airlines and cargo operators
Airport Director / Manager	Aviation management degree plus experience; city, county, and airport authority jobs
Aviation Logistics	Supply chain degree or certificate plus aviation knowledge; airline operations and MRO supply
Flight School Owner / CFI	CFI and CFII ratings plus a business plan; earn revenue while building flight hours
Aviation Curriculum Developer	Teaching certificate plus aviation credentials; growing with STEM programs nationwide
Aviation Insurance Underwriter	Finance or business degree plus FAA knowledge; a niche field, and well paid

★ **CAREER ALERT:** Dispatchers share operational control of the flight with the captain — a licensed airline career with no flight hours required.

SECTION 9

Where to Go & What to Do Next

Four steps, in order: Explore, Connect, Train, Apply.

Explore → Connect → Train → Apply

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Step 1 — Explore (Free Resources)

RESOURCE	WHAT YOU FIND THERE
FAA Career Resources — faa.gov/jobs	Every FAA career path, hiring portals, and the AT-CTI schools list
AOPA — aopa.org	Pilot resources, flight training finder, and a scholarship database
EAA — eaa.org	Youth aviation programs, the Ray Scholarship, and local chapters
Tuskegee Airmen Inc. — tuskegeeairmen.org	Scholarships, mentorship, and legacy chapters nationwide
Women in Aviation Int'l — wai.org	Annual scholarships, mentors, and a careers database
OBAP — obap.org	Mentorship, scholarships, networking, and a career pipeline
Airlines for America — airlines.org	Industry data, workforce reports, and career pathways
USAJOBS — usajobs.gov	All federal aviation jobs: FAA, DoD, NASA, TSA, Space Force
AviationStart — aviationstart.com	$20M+ AI scholarship database; Jamail Larkins, FAA Ambassador
eVTOL.Travel / AirTaxiCentral.com	Powered-lift career tracking; company hiring status updates

Step 2 — Connect (Get in a Room)

Local EAA Chapter — eaa.org/chapters
Young Eagles flights are FREE for ages 8–17.

Attend an Air Show
Talk to every exhibitor in the career tent. Collect names, not just brochures.

Join OBAP
Organization of Black Aerospace Professionals — mentorship plus scholarships.

Join Women in Aviation International (WAI)
Open to ALL; one of the largest scholarship programs in the industry.

Civil Air Patrol
Free aerospace education, leadership training, and scholarships.

I/ITSEC and Aviation Week Conferences
Defense, simulation, and aerospace exposure with hiring managers present.

★ **CAREER ALERT:** AOPA's research found students quit over lost momentum and poor communication far more often than raw cost. Mentors solve both.

Step 3 — Train (Funded Pathways)

FUNDING SOURCE	WHAT IT COVERS
GI Bill / Chapter 33	Full tuition plus housing for veterans at Part 141 schools and universities
VR&E (Vocational Rehabilitation & Employment)	Covers 100% of training for service-connected disabled veterans
Florida SUFS Scholarship	Aviation STEM, tutoring, and drone courses for eligible K-12 families
WIOA (Workforce Innovation & Opportunity Act)	CareerSource-funded training for eligible adults in career transition
AOPA Foundation Scholarship	Student pilot training scholarships — aopa.org/scholarships
EAA Ray Aviation Scholarship	Up to $10,000 for student pilots — eaa.org/rayscholarship
Airlines for America Pathways	United Aviate, American Cadet, Delta Propel, Southwest 225° — sponsored ATP pipelines
Pell Grant + FAFSA	Community college aviation programs are Pell-eligible
FAA Workforce Development Grants	Round 4 (2025) open to nonprofits, school districts, and accredited institutions — faa.gov

★ **MAA GUIDANCE:** MAA families start with SUFS and WIOA. Veterans start with VR&E. Nobody pays retail before checking all nine.

Step 4 — Apply (Hiring Portals)

FEDERAL	**usajobs.gov** FAA, NASA, TSA, DoD, and Space Force — all GS-series federal jobs.	GENERAL	**Indeed / LinkedIn** Search ‘aviation’ plus your city or your specialty.
AIRLINES	**Airline career portals** United, Delta, American, Southwest, FedEx, UPS.	DEFENSE	**Contractor careers** Lockheed Martin, Northrop Grumman, Raytheon, Boeing careers pages.
INDUSTRY	**AeroCareers.com / avjobs.com** Pilot, dispatch, maintenance, and operations listings.	eVTOL	**eVTOL company career pages** Joby, Archer, Wisk, Blade — hiring aggressively in 2026.

★ **SEQUENCE:** Federal hiring runs the slowest clock — FAA cycles run 6 to 18 months. File usajobs.gov first, then work the commercial portals.

SECTION 10

Aviation Career Salary Snapshot

Industry ranges first, then BLS-verified national medians.

BLS medians are the figures to use in grant and sponsor materials.

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Salary Snapshot — Entry vs. Experienced

CAREER	ENTRY SALARY	EXPERIENCED
Airline Pilot (ATP / Major)	$80K–$100K (Regional)	**$250K–$350K+**
A&P Mechanic	$45K–$55K	**$80K–$120K+**
Air Traffic Controller (FAA)	$60K–$70K	**$140K–$180K+**
Corporate / Charter Pilot	$90K–$120K	**$220K–$350K+**
Aerospace Engineer	$74K–$102K	**$134K–$205K+ (BLS)**
UAS / Drone Operator	$40K–$55K	**$75K–$150K (specialist)**
eVTOL Pilot	$80K–$100K (FO entry)	**$130K–$180K (Captain)**
Helicopter Pilot (EMS / Offshore)	$45K–$65K (CFI-H entry)	**$90K–$175K+**

★ **READ THE RIGHT COLUMN:** These are industry ranges and vary by region, employer, and seniority. The next slide gives the federally verified medians for citation.

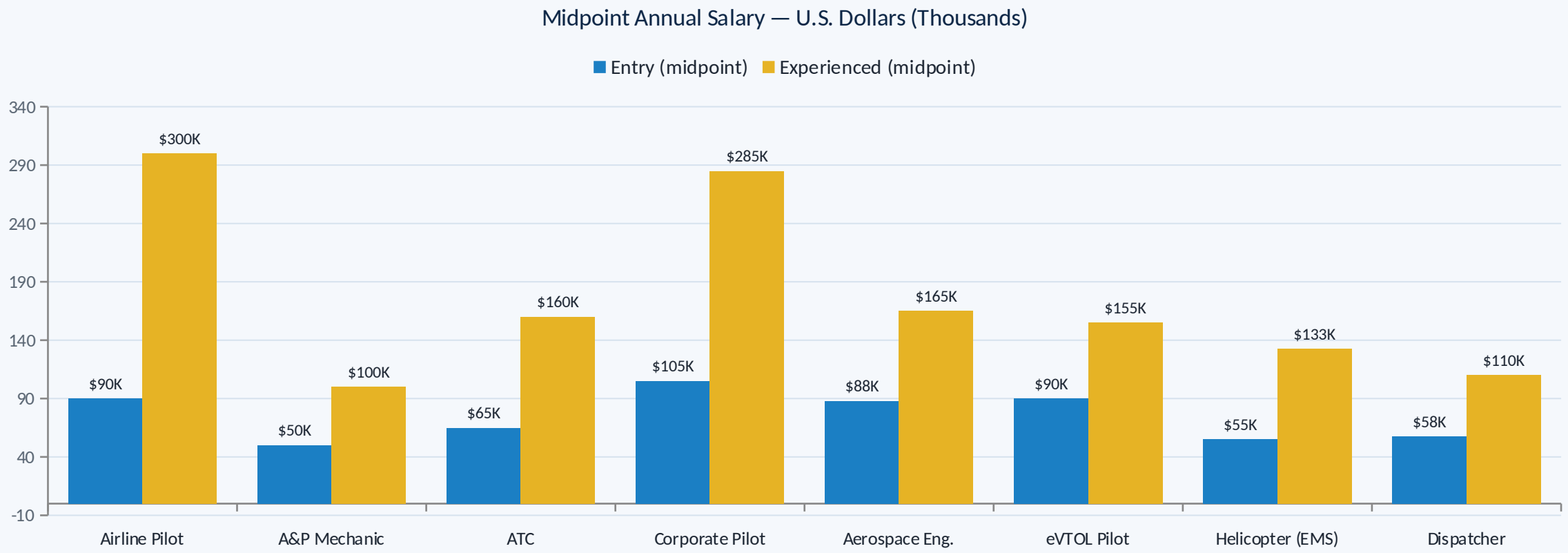
BLS-Verified National Medians (May 2024)

Use these figures — not industry ranges — in grant applications, ETPL submissions, and sponsor materials.

OCCUPATION (BLS CATEGORY)	MEDIAN ANNUAL WAGE	10-YEAR OUTLOOK (2024–34)
Airline Pilots, Copilots & Flight Engineers	**$226,600**	+4% — about as fast as average
Commercial Pilots	**$122,670**	Included in pilot category
Air Traffic Controllers	**$144,580**	+1% — slower than average
Aerospace Engineers	**$134,830**	+6% — faster than average
Avionics Technicians	**$81,390**	+5% — faster than average
Aircraft Mechanics & Service Technicians	**$78,680**	+5% — faster than average
Aerospace Engineering Technologists & Techs	**$79,830**	+8% — much faster than average
Flight Attendants	**$67,130**	Growth reported by BLS
All U.S. Occupations (benchmark)	$49,500	—

★ **BENCHMARK:** The median U.S. worker earned $49,500 in May 2024. Six of the eight aviation occupations above pay more than 1.5 times that, and four require no four-year degree.

Earnings Range by Career Track



Midpoints of the published industry ranges. Corporate pilot, eVTOL, and helicopter are new additions in v7.

SECTION 11–14

Plan Your Path: Cost, Eligibility & First Steps

What it costs, how long it takes, who qualifies, why most people quit — and exactly what to do in your first twelve months.

This is the section most career guides leave out.

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What It Costs and How Long It Takes

CREDENTIAL	TYPICAL COST (2026)	TYPICAL TIME	NOTES
FAA Part 107 Remote Pilot	**$175 test + prep**	2–6 weeks	Lowest-cost legitimate aviation credential
Private Pilot License (PPL)	**$15,000–$20,000**	3–12 months	FAA minimum is 40 hrs; most students need 60–75
Zero to Airline-Ready	**$60,000–$120,000**	18 months–3 years	PPL+IR+CPL+ME+CFI; Part 61 lower, structured higher
A&P Certificate	**Varies by school**	18–24 months	Or 30 months documented experience, then testing
eVTOL Powered-Lift Transition	**$15,000–$25,000**	40–50 hrs	Added to existing Commercial certificate; operator-funded in many cases
Helicopter Zero-to-Commercial	**$50,000–$75,000**	6–12 months	Separate certificate; EMS/offshore hire at 1,000–2,000 hrs
ATC (FAA Academy path)	**No tuition — FAA pays**	6–18 mo + 1–3 yr OJT	Paid during Academy; must be under 31 at application

★ **COST DISCIPLINE:** The biggest cost variable is not the hourly rate — it is how long you take. Training 3–5 times per week costs far less in total than training once a week.

Who Qualifies — Check This Before You Spend

FAA MEDICAL CERTIFICATES		
CLASS	**REQUIRED FOR**	**TYPICAL VALIDITY**
First Class	Airline Transport Pilot — airline captains and first officers	6–12 months depending on age
Second Class	Commercial Pilot — any paid flying	12 months
Third Class	Private Pilot, Student Pilot, Recreational	24–60 months depending on age
BasicMed	Private pilot privileges in qualifying aircraft, in lieu of Third Class	Per BasicMed rule requirements
No FAA medical	Part 107 remote pilot; glider and balloon operations	Not applicable

AGE, CITIZENSHIP & BACKGROUND GATES	
GATE	**REQUIREMENT**
Age minimums	14 — solo glider/balloon | 16 — solo airplane and Part 107 | 17 — Private Pilot | 18 — Commercial | 23 — ATP (21 restricted)
Air traffic control	U.S. citizen; under 31 at application (limited veteran exceptions — verify per announcement); ATSA test; medical and background checks
Defense & intelligence	U.S. citizenship and a security clearance (Secret to TS/SCI); background investigation required

★ **DO THIS FIRST:** See an Aviation Medical Examiner before spending a dollar on flight training. The FAA issues thousands of Special Issuance medicals each year — do not assume you are disqualified.

Military Experience → Civilian Aviation Credential

MILITARY BACKGROUND	CIVILIAN CREDENTIAL IT FEEDS	HOW IT SHORTENS THE PATH
Aircraft maintenance (AF 2A, Navy AD/AE/AME, Army 15-series)	FAA A&P Certificate	Documented experience counts toward A&P testing eligibility
Military ATC (AF 1C1X1, Army 15Q, Navy AC)	FAA Air Traffic Controller	Direct hiring pathway; qualifying experience may support a veteran age exception
Military pilot	Commercial / ATP	ATP minimum drops from 1,500 hrs to 750 hrs
Intelligence, cyber, ISR	Intelligence Analyst, Cyber / Space roles	Existing clearance is often the hardest credential to obtain
Any honorable service	Any FAA credential	GI Bill Chapter 33 and VR&E fund training; VR&E covers 100% for service-connected disabled veterans

★ **VETERAN PRIORITY:** MAA is led by a retired Naval officer and 100% disabled veteran. Bring your DD-214 and training records to the first conversation — they are worth money and months.

Why Most People Quit — and How You Won't

THE ATTRITION RATE

~80%

of student pilots quit before earning a certificate (AOPA research; reaffirmed at NAFI Summit 2025).

THE REAL CAUSE

Momentum

AOPA found the top drivers are lost momentum, poor communication, and being misled on time and money — not cost or aptitude.

THE MAA ANSWER

Structure

Published syllabus, assigned mentor, milestone tracking, and transparent cost expectations from day one.

THE FOUR DANGER WINDOWS — KNOW THEM BEFORE YOU HIT THEM

WINDOW	WHAT HAPPENS	HOW TO SURVIVE IT
First 15 hours	Progress feels slow and landings feel impossible	Fly 2–3 times per week; expect the plateau
Pre-solo (20–30 hrs)	Performance anxiety, instructor changes, weather delays	Keep the same CFI; use a sim for procedures
Post-solo (30–60 hrs)	Knowledge test anxiety and budget fatigue	Pass the written early; lock in funding before you start
Pre-checkride	Fear of failure this close to the finish	Mock orals and a scheduled DPE date

★ **THE WHOLE POINT:** The map is what the other 80% never had. Knowing where the cliffs are is most of what it takes to get past them.

The Twelve-Month Action Plan

DAYS 1–30

Decide & Qualify

- Pick ONE career family from Section 1
- Book an AME appointment and get your medical
- Take a discovery flight or a drone session
- Create your usajobs.gov profile

DAYS 31–90

Fund & Enroll

- Apply to every scholarship you qualify for
- File FAFSA; check SUFS, WIOA, GI Bill, VR&E
- Enroll in Part 107 or ground school
- Join EAA, OBAP, WAI, or CAP

MONTHS 4–6

Train & Test

- Pass the FAA Knowledge Test for your track
- Fly or study 2–3 times per week — protect momentum
- Find a mentor and check in monthly
- Log everything from day one

MONTHS 7–12

Certify & Apply

- Earn the first credential — Part 107, PPL, or A&P testing
- Build a résumé around the credential
- Apply through the Section 9 portals
- Set the next rung and repeat the cycle

★ **ONE YEAR FROM TODAY:** A credential in hand, a mentor on speed dial, and a funded plan for the next rung. That is a realistic twelve months — if you start this week.

SECTION 15

Sport Pilot, Glider & the Stacked Ladder

There is a lower, earlier, cheaper set of rungs than the Private Pilot certificate.

A student may legally solo a glider at 14.

MAA

INFINITY FACT ABAC CLUB TAMPA

The Real Age Gates

CERTIFICATE	MIN AGE	MINIMUM FLIGHT TIME	NOTE
Solo — glider or balloon	**14**	Instructor endorsement	The earliest a person may legally fly an aircraft alone in the United States
Private Pilot — Glider	**16**	10 hours, 20 flights	The fewest hours to any full FAA pilot certificate
FAA Part 107 Remote Pilot	**16**	No flight time	Knowledge test only — the first rung that pays
Sport Pilot	**17**	20 hours	Driver's license may substitute for an FAA medical
Private Pilot — Airplane	**17**	40 hours	Most students need 60–75 hours in practice
Commercial Pilot — Glider	**18**	25 hours	First certificate that allows you to be paid to fly
CFI — Glider	**18**	No hours beyond Commercial	Instruction hours count toward the 1,500-hour ATP
Commercial Pilot — Airplane	**18**	250 hours	The airplane ladder's paid rung
Airline Transport Pilot	**23**	1,500 hours	Restricted ATP at 21 under 14 CFR 61.160

★ **READ THE FIRST ROW AGAIN:** A student may legally solo a glider at fourteen — three years before a classmate can solo an airplane, and at roughly one-fifth the cost.

Sport Pilot After MOSAIC

The FAA MOSAIC rule reshaped the sport pilot certificate in two phases: privileges expanded October 22, 2025, and light-sport aircraft certification changed July 24, 2026.

WHAT CHANGED	DETAIL
Aircraft you may fly	Defined by performance, not weight. Clean stall speed at or below 59 knots CAS, up to four seats (14 CFR 61.316)
Night flight	Now permitted with an endorsement plus BasicMed or a third-class medical
Getting paid as pilot in command	**Still prohibited. A sport pilot may not carry passengers or property for compensation, nor fly in furtherance of a business**
Aerial work	Since July 24, 2026, qualifying light-sport aircraft may perform paid aerial photography, survey, pipeline and powerline patrol, and banner towing under 14 CFR 91.327
Sport pilot instructor pay	**MOSAIC added 14 CFR 61.413(d), expressly authorizing compensation for a CFI with a Sport Pilot rating. Effective October 22, 2025.**

★ **THE INCOME RULE:** Sport Pilot is a cost rung, not an income rung. The CFI-Sport Pilot certificate above it is the rung that pays, and MOSAIC made that explicit in 2025.

The Stacked Ladder — How the Rungs Connect

Three ladders, one career. Each costs more to reach the instructor level than the one before it — which is exactly why the motorglider comes first.

RUNG	AIRCRAFT	CERTIFICATES & AGES	ALL-IN COST
Rung 1 — Glider	Motorglider	Solo at 14 · Private Glider at 16 (10 hrs) · Commercial Glider at 18 (25 hrs) · CFI-Glider adds no hours	**$6,880–$8,050**
Rung 2 — Light Sport	LSA trainer	Sport Pilot at 17 (20 hrs) · CFI-S requires 150 hrs total time (14 CFR 61.411)	**$22,475–$26,425**

WHAT EACH RUNG PAYS — [BLS] FEDERALLY VERIFIED · [MKT] MARKET-OBSERVED · [REG] SET BY REGULATION

ROLE	INCOME	CLASS
FAA Part 107 Remote Pilot (age 16)	First paid work on the ladder — offsets glider training cost	[MKT]
CFI-Glider (club or commercial)	$20–$30/hr	[MKT]
CFI-Glider (independent)	$40–$60/hr	[MKT]
Commercial Pilot–Glider	$25–$40 per ride flight; $16K–$40K/yr by season	[MKT]
Stacked: Comm-G + CFI-G + tow	$45,000–$70,000/yr at one operation, full season	[MKT]

★ **WHY THIS MATTERS:** CFI-Glider hours count toward the 1,500 hours the ATP requires (14 CFR 61.159). Glider instruction is ATP-qualifying flight time bought at a fraction of airplane rates.

SECTION 16

The Aviation Wealth Ladder v11.22

Age 14 to age 30 and beyond. Every rung, every certificate, and what each one pays — from Your Aviation Blueprint, Chapter 1.

One career. One percent at a time.

MAA

Where This Career Actually Lands You

TOP 10%

$169,000+

U.S. household income threshold.

TOP 5%

$339,000+

A senior regional captain reaches this band.

TOP 1%

$889,000+

Household threshold for the top one percent.

TOP 0.1%

$3M+

The upper bound of the income distribution.

The Argument

A major airline captain earning $250,000 to $500,000 sits inside the top 1–5% of American earners. Aviation is not a path to the median — it is a direct path to the top, and the first rung starts at fourteen with a glider.

★ **SOURCE:** Income percentile thresholds as cited in Your Aviation Blueprint, Chapter 1. Pathway data corrected to v11.21 (the Vollmer Pathway). Wealth Ladder updated to v11.22.

The Ladder — Age 14 to Age 30+

AGE	RUNG	CERTIFICATE / REGULATION	WHAT IT PAYS
14	Motorglider solo	Student certificate, CFI-G endorsement	$0 — cost phase
16	Private Pilot–Glider + Part 107	10 hrs minimum — fewest hrs to any full FAA certificate	**Drone income begins**
17	Sport Pilot	20 hrs, 14 CFR 61.315	$0 as PIC
18	Commercial Glider + CFI-Glider	25 hrs total; CFI-G adds no hours beyond that	**First paid flying [MKT]**
18–21	CFI-G + CFI-S + drone business	Stacked instruction and Part 107 commercial work	**$60K–$80K/yr [MKT]**
21	Restricted ATP	14 CFR 61.160 — first officer only	**Regional FO [BLS]**
21+	eVTOL Powered-Lift rating	Commercial + 250 hrs + 40–50 hrs PL transition	**eVTOL FO $80K–$100K [MKT]**
23	Unrestricted ATP	14 CFR 61.159 — 1,500 hrs	**Full ATP [BLS]**
28–30	Regional Captain / Major FO	Seniority-driven	**Six figures [BLS]**
30+	Major Airline Captain	Top of the fixed-wing ladder	**$250K–$500K [BLS]**

★ **THE COMPOUNDING RULE:** Every rung above 16 pays for the rung above it. The student who solos a motorglider at 14 does not borrow their way to an ATP — they earn their way there.

The Vollmer Pathway — Three Rungs, One Ladder

A glider has no engine. A motorglider has one: it takes off under its own power, and a student can fly it powered or shut the engine down and soar it, in the same flight. One aircraft delivers both glider time and genuine powered airplane time.

RAND'S OWN NUMBERS

By age 16

Roughly $5,000 all-in on the glider ladder — offset to functionally zero by summer Part 107 drone earnings between 16 and 18.

Age 18 to 21

A paid flight instructor running a drone business earning $60,000 to $80,000 a year — funding the LSA and Airplane ladders out of income, not debt.

Equipment note

A TAA-equipped LSA delivers real credit toward Rung 3 that a non-TAA aircraft cannot (14 CFR 61.129(j)).

THE REGULATIONS THAT CONTROL THE MONEY

REGULATION	WHY IT MATTERS TO INCOME
14 CFR 61.413(d)	MOSAIC expressly authorized paying a CFI-Sport Pilot. Effective October 22, 2025 — the newest income door on the ladder
14 CFR 61.159	CFI-Glider hours count toward the 1,500-hour ATP requirement — ATP-qualifying time at a fraction of airplane rates
14 CFR 61.160	Restricted ATP at 21 instead of 23 — two years of airline earnings recovered

Attribution: The Vollmer Pathway is the work of Rand Vollmer, Colonel, U.S. Army (Ret.) — CFI-Glider, LSRM, DARPA Soaring SME. A fifteen-year documented model.

SECTION 17

Aerospace, Space & Mechanical Engineering

From aircraft structures to Mars missions — the engineering tracks aviation opens, and what each one pays.

$134,830 BLS median. Top earners exceed $270,000.

MAA

Specializations & Where the Premium Pay Sits

Aerospace engineering splits into two primary disciplines: Aeronautical (aircraft within the atmosphere) and Astronautical (spacecraft beyond it). Most employers don't strictly enforce that line.

SPECIALIZATIONS — WHERE THE PREMIUM PAY SITS

SPECIALIZATION	WHAT YOU DO	PAY PREMIUM VS. MEDIAN
Propulsion & Rocket Engines	Design and test engines, turbines, rocket motors, electric propulsion systems	15–25% above median — SpaceX Raptor, GE Aviation, Pratt & Whitney
Guidance, Navigation & Control (GNC)	Algorithms and systems that tell an aircraft or spacecraft where it is and where to go	20–30% above median — heavy demand in autonomous and space systems
Structures & Materials	Stress analysis, composites, fatigue testing — the skeleton of every aircraft	At or near median; moves up with composites/advanced materials specialty
Avionics & Systems Integration	Flight computers, sensors, cockpit systems, data links	10–20% above median — growing with eVTOL and autonomous systems
Orbital Mechanics & Mission Design	Trajectory planning, launch windows, satellite operations	Premium — narrow field, high demand at NASA/JPL, Rocket Lab, Planet Labs
Flight Test Engineering	Live-aircraft testing, data reduction, airworthiness validation	Niche, high prestige, 15–20% above median

★ **BLS ANCHOR:** Aerospace engineer national median: $134,830 (May 2024). Entry-level range: $74K–$102K. Top 10% clear $205,850. Active security clearance adds $5K–$15K on day one.

Pay by Employer — NASA vs. SpaceX vs. Defense Primes

EMPLOYER / SECTOR	ENTRY SALARY	MID-CAREER	TOP EARNERS	NOTES
SpaceX (Hawthorne CA / Starbase TX / Cape Canaveral)	$95K–$120K + equity	$165K–$200K	$270K+ (90th pct.)	Intense pace; learn 5 years of experience in 2
NASA / FFRDCs (JPL, APL, ARC)	$55K–$75K (GS-7 to GS-9)	$100K–$130K	$160K+ (SES)	Federal pay scale; mission work; stability; pension
Lockheed Martin	$99K+ (E1 entry)	$130K–$160K	$200K+	Defense programs; clearance a day-one differentiator
Boeing / Northrop / Raytheon	$85K–$105K	$120K–$155K	$190K+	Large-program, process-heavy; strong benefits
Blue Origin / Rocket Lab / Planet Labs	$95K–$115K + equity	$145K–$185K	$250K+	Commercial space growth; equity upside; faster pace
U.S. Space Force (civilian / military)	GS-7+: $55K–$160K | military O-1 to O-6	Promotions + BAH	SES / GO/FO	Newest military branch; most roles still being defined

★ **ACTIVE CLEARANCE:** A Secret or higher security clearance adds $5K–$15K to the day-one offer — and unlocks half the jobs that don't appear on public job boards. Veteran military service is the fastest path to one.

The Space Economy — A Parallel Track

The commercial space industry is no longer a subset of aerospace. It is its own sector — faster, higher-paying at the entry level, and actively recruiting from aviation pipelines.

ROCKET & SPACECRAFT

$95K–$270K+

SpaceX · Rocket Lab · Blue Origin · Sierra Space · Vast

Propulsion, structures, GNC, systems integration

SATELLITE & EARTH OBSERVATION

$85K–$180K

Planet Labs · Maxar · HawkEye360 · Spire Global

Remote sensing, data analytics, mission ops

SPACE DEFENSE & INTELLIGENCE

$72K–$200K+

Space Force · NRO · NGA · L3Harris Space Division

TS/SCI clearance = premium pay and access

LAUNCH & OPERATIONS

$80K–$175K

United Launch Alliance · Relativity Space · ABL Space

Range safety, launch ops, flight control

SPACE MEDICINE

$127K–$203K

NASA · Virgin Galactic · Axiom Space · SpaceVIP

GROUND SYSTEMS & IT

$90K–$200K

AWS Ground Station · Azure Space · Viasat

★ **TEXAS SOUTHERN NOTE:** Texas Southern University at Houston Spaceport opened 2026 with a $5.5M investment — the first HBCU-anchored aviation and space workforce pipeline connected directly to NASA's Johnson Space Center.

SECTION 18

eVTOL & Urban Air Mobility — The New Pilot Career

The fastest-growing pilot category in aviation. First commercial operations in 2026. Thousands of pilots needed by 2030.

FAA Powered-Lift rating now exists. The door is open.

MAA

What It Is, Where It Stands, and Why It Matters Now

eVTOL — electric vertical takeoff and landing — is a quiet, electric aircraft that lifts like a helicopter and cruises like a fixed-wing airplane, turning a 90-minute drive into a 7-minute hop.

WHERE EACH MAJOR COMPANY STANDS — FALL 2026

COMPANY	CERTIFICATION STATUS	PLANNED OPERATIONS	HIRING?
Joby Aviation	Stage 4 of 5 FAA type cert.; production-conforming aircraft flying	U.S. operations 2026 under White House eIPP; NYC, LA, SF	**YES — Joby Academy operational**
Archer Aviation (Midnight)	First to close Phase 3 of FAA 4-phase process; first 100% Means of Compliance acceptance	Initial U.S. ops 2026; Official Air Taxi Provider — LA28 Olympics	**YES — pipeline building**
Wisk Aero	Autonomous-first design; FAA type certification in progress	Long-term; fully autonomous target	**Engineers + ops roles**
Beta Technologies (ALIA CX300)	Targeting early certification 2026	Cargo and medical logistics first	**Building**
EHang EH216-S	CAAC certified (China); commercial passenger flights active in Guangzhou, Hefei	**Operating NOW — not FAA certified**	International only

★ **THE BOTTOM LINE:** Joby and Archer have cleared the hardest FAA gates. First commercial U.S. passenger operations are in progress in 2026. This is no longer a future technology.

How to Become an eVTOL Pilot — The Requirements

Two myths: (1) the aircraft fly themselves — the FAA mandates human pilots through at least 2035. (2) The training is impossibly complex — if you already have your Commercial certificate, the transition is 40–50 hours.

PREREQUISITES — THE FULL CHECKLIST

REQUIREMENT	DETAIL	TIMING
Commercial Pilot Certificate	FAA Commercial (airplane or helicopter) — the baseline license that allows paid flying	Already on the Career Guide ladder — see Section 2
250 Total Flight Hours	Minimum before powered-lift training begins; most entrants arrive with 500–1,000 hrs	Built through CFI work, regional flying, Part 135 charter
Current FAA Medical Certificate	At minimum a Third Class; First or Second Class preferred for commercial ops	Same medical the PPL requires — see Section 12
FAA Powered-Lift (PL) Rating	New rating category established in the 2024 final rule; specific to eVTOL-type aircraft	40–50 hours of specialized training; ~$15,000–$25,000 total cost
Type Rating (aircraft-specific)	Required for the specific eVTOL model you will fly (e.g., Joby S4)	Provided by the operator — typically paid by the hiring company

★ **THE PATH:** Commercial certificate + 250 hrs + Powered-Lift transition = the eVTOL cockpit. The student who earns a CFI at 18 can reach 250 hours before age 21 and be positioned for first-generation eVTOL hiring.

eVTOL Pilot Salary, Employers & Who Is Hiring

ROLE	SALARY RANGE	WHO IS HIRING	CLASS
eVTOL First Officer (entry)	$80K–$100K/yr	Joby Aviation, Archer Aviation, Blade Air Mobility	[MKT]
eVTOL Captain	$130K–$180K/yr	Joby, Archer, Volocopter (international), Lilium operations	[MKT]
Chief Pilot / Director of Operations	$150K–$220K+/yr	Early-stage operators building safety culture from scratch	[MKT]
eVTOL Maintenance Technician	$65K–$95K/yr	Joby, Archer, BETA — battery, fly-by-wire, software; A&P required	[MKT]
Simulator / Transition Instructor	$55K–$85K/yr	Joby Academy, CAE, FlightSafety International eVTOL programs	[MKT]
Software / Autonomy Engineer	$120K–$200K/yr	Wisk, Joby, Archer, Aurora Flight Sciences (Boeing)	[MKT]
Regulatory / Certification Specialist	$90K–$160K/yr	All operators need FAA/EASA navigation specialists; rare talent pool	[MKT]

★ **100,000+ JOBS BY 2030:** The eVTOL industry is projected to exceed 100,000 jobs by 2030 across pilots, maintenance, software, operations, and infrastructure. First-generation entrants set the standard for the entire industry.

SECTION 19

Helicopter Pilot: A Completely Different Career

A separate certificate, a separate aircraft, and a separate career world. The only thing it shares with fixed-wing is the sky.

EMS captains earn $90K–$175K+. The offshore sector exceeds that.

Seven Civilian Sectors — One Certificate Opens All of Them

A Commercial Pilot–Helicopter certificate is a separate FAA rating from any fixed-wing certificate. The skills, aircraft, and career markets are distinct — but the income ceiling is comparable.

EMS / AIR AMBULANCE

$90K–$175K+

24/7 ops; 1,000–2,000 hrs + IFR + turbine required; most rewarding and demanding sector

OFFSHORE OIL & GAS

$100K–$175K+

Long rotations; HUET certification; highest civilian pay in the sector

LAW ENFORCEMENT

$70K–$100K

City/county/state agencies; lower hour minimums than EMS; steady schedule + benefits

CORPORATE / VIP TRANSPORT

$90K–$150K+

High-net-worth clients; flexible scheduling; IFR and turbine preferred

TOUR & AERIAL WORK

$50K–$80K

Grand Canyon, Hawaii, NYC; entry-level commercial; fastest path to 500 hrs

NEWS / ELECTRONIC NEWSGATHERING

$65K–$95K

Camera-equipped helicopters; precision flying in urban airspace; often union

MILITARY (ARMY, NAVY, MARINES, USCG)

Flight pay + BAH + benefits; $100K–$180K+ total comp

No personal training cost; commitment required; GI Bill afterward

★ **CAREER ALERT:** Seven sectors, one certificate. Helicopter pilots with EMS, offshore, or corporate experience who transition to eVTOL are among the most competitive candidates in the new powered-lift market.

Training Path, Hour Requirements & Pay Timeline

Helicopter training is separate from and more expensive than fixed-wing. The central planning problem is the gap between graduation hours and EMS/offshore hire minimums.

THE PATH — ZERO TO PROFESSIONAL

STAGE	HOURS	TYPICAL COST	PAY	HOW TO BRIDGE THE GAP
Student Pilot — first solo	~30 hrs	Included in program	$0	Flight school progression
Private Pilot–Helicopter	40 hrs minimum	$15K–$25K	$0 — cost phase	Most students need 60–80 hrs
Commercial Pilot–Helicopter	150 hrs total time	$50K–$75K total zero-to-Commercial	$0 — cert phase	Core credential; now eligible for paid work
CFI-Helicopter (hour builder)	200+ hrs at issue	Included in above	$45K–$65K/yr	The hour-building strategy — teaching while flying
Tour / Aerial Work entry	500–1,000 hrs	Already earned	$50K–$80K/yr	First commercial ops; insurance-eligible
EMS / Law Enforcement entry	1,000–2,000 hrs + IFR + turbine	Accrued over time	$90K–$130K/yr	The insurance minimum is the real gate — not the FAA cert
Offshore / Senior EMS Captain	3,000–5,000+ hrs	—	$120K–$175K+/yr	Chief pilot track available above this level

★ **THE HOUR PROBLEM:** When you finish a professional helicopter program, you exit with roughly 200 hours. EMS and offshore hire at 1,000–2,000. That gap is the central planning challenge — and CFI-H work is the standard solution.

What Mission Aviation Academy Delivers

FAA Part 107 Remote Pilot Course
Classroom and cohort-based training at X39 — the fastest route to a credential.

FAA Private Pilot Ground School
Five delivery tracks: 4-week intensive, 8-week standard, summer camps, and micro-lessons.

Flight Training at Tampa North Aero Park
Instruction in the academy's Cessna 172 trainer with Walter Matthews, CFI; Phil Mednick, CFI; and Ahviyona Floyd, CFI/CFII/MEI.

Glider & Sport Pilot Pathway
The stacked ladder in Section 15 — the earliest and lowest-cost route into aviation.

Discovery Flights & Drone Workshops
First-flight experiences and hands-on STEM sessions for youth and community groups.

Scholarships
Brave Bess Scholarship and the Tuskegee 1st Top Gun Trophy Scholarship for MAA students.

Scholarship & Funding Navigation
Help applying for SUFS, WIOA, GI Bill, VR&E, and national aviation scholarships.

★ **FLIGHT PLAN 2030:** 300,000+ youth impacted. 722+ FAA credentials issued. 1,380+ students flown. Target: one million youth reached by 2030.

YOUR NEXT STEP

Pick ONE career family.
Research ONE resource.
Make ONE phone call.

The aviation world is waiting for people who look like you.

ONE FAMILY

Section 1 lists all 7 career families.

ONE RESOURCE

Section 9, Step 1 lists ten free resources.

ONE CALL

813-445-8889 · (833) FLY-STEM

Connect With Our Aviation & Aerospace Experts

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- admissions@missionaviationacademy.org
- Infinity Aero Club Tampa — iACT

Our team of aviation and aerospace professionals is ready to help you find your path.

JOIN OUR WAITLIST

CAREER GUIDE

Data Sources and Currency

FIGURE USED IN THIS GUIDE	SOURCE	AS OF
Median wages for all aviation occupations	U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook	May 2024
674,000 pilots / 728,000 technicians / 1,023,000 cabin crew	Boeing Pilot & Technician Outlook 2026–2045	2026
Mechanic shortage 10% (2025) narrowing to 7% (2035)	ATEC / Oliver Wyman Pipeline Report	2025
493,396 remote pilot certificates	FAA Aerospace Forecast FY 2026–2046	Dec 2025
ATC under-31 rule; $155,000+ certified earnings	Federal Aviation Administration, faa.gov/atc-hiring	2026
~80% student pilot dropout rate	AOPA flight training research; SAFE; NAFI Summit 2025	2025
MOSAIC provisions and effective dates	FAA MOSAIC final rule — Phase I Oct 22, 2025; Phase II Jul 24, 2026	2026
eVTOL pilot salary $80K–$180K; hiring status	eVTOL.Travel, AirTaxiCentral.com, FutureWatchLog	2026
eVTOL certification milestones (Joby, Archer)	Company investor relations; FutureWatchLog July 2026	2026
Helicopter salary ranges by sector	Pilot Institute, US Aviation Training Solutions, Helicopted.com	2026
Aerospace engineer pay by employer (SpaceX, NASA, Lockheed)	Glassdoor, Articuler/Careerscape, Glassdoor, OPM GS tables	Aug 2026
Corporate pilot avg $202,499	BizJetJobs survey, 2,847 pilots	2026
Wealth Ladder ages, costs, and income ranges	Vollmer Pathway — Your Aviation Blueprint v11.22	2026

★ **VERIFICATION STANDARD:** Cite BLS figures in grant, ETPL, and sponsor submissions. Market figures are directional — label them as ranges, not verified medians. Review all figures before each reprint.

LCDR Ricardo “Tattoo” Foster, USN (Ret.)

Founder & Chief Executive Officer · Infinity Aero Club Tampa Bay, Inc. / Mission Aviation Academy

- 36 years of combined service: 28 years of military service in naval aviation intelligence, U.S. Navy (Retired), plus 8 years of civilian aviation and education experience.
- 100% disabled veteran; mentored directly by the Tuskegee Airmen.
- Founder and CEO of a Florida 501(c)(3) delivering aviation, STEM, AI, and entrepreneurship pathways to underserved youth.
- Program Lead and Ground Instructor, FAA Private Pilot and Part 107 Remote Pilot programs at Tampa North Aero Park (X39).
- Architect of Flight Plan 2030 — one million youth reached and $10 million raised by 2030.

300,000+
Youth impacted

722+
FAA credentials issued

1,380+
Students flown

Published by Tactical Drones Academy & Simulations — A commercial imprint of Infinity Aero Club Tampa Bay, Inc. (iACT) — 501(c)(3) and academic wing d/b/a Mission Aviation Academy